

a judgment, the assessment was based on the available information, and attempts were planned to contact study investigators for clarification. RoB plot was created using the Risk-of-bias VISualization (robvis) tool.¹⁸

Synthesis Methods

A formal quantitative meta-analysis was not planned. Instead, findings were synthesized using a structured narrative approach. This decision was made a priori because the number of eligible studies was expected to be small, and heterogeneity was anticipated across study populations, HRT formulations and regimens, timing of initiation, follow-up duration, and reported outcomes. The evidence was therefore synthesized qualitatively.

Results

Study Selection

Study selection was conducted in accordance with the predefined eligibility criteria. Of the 1701 records initially identified, 311 duplicates were removed, and the remaining 1390 records underwent title and abstract screening. A total of 1231 records were excluded at this stage, and 159 reports were sought for full-text retrieval. Of these, 3 reports were not retrieved and 156 full-text reports were assessed for eligibility. Following full-text review, 150 reports were excluded, primarily because they used non-randomized study designs or did not include findings relevant to women aged 65 years and older. In total, 6 studies met the inclusion criteria and were included in the final review (Figure 1).

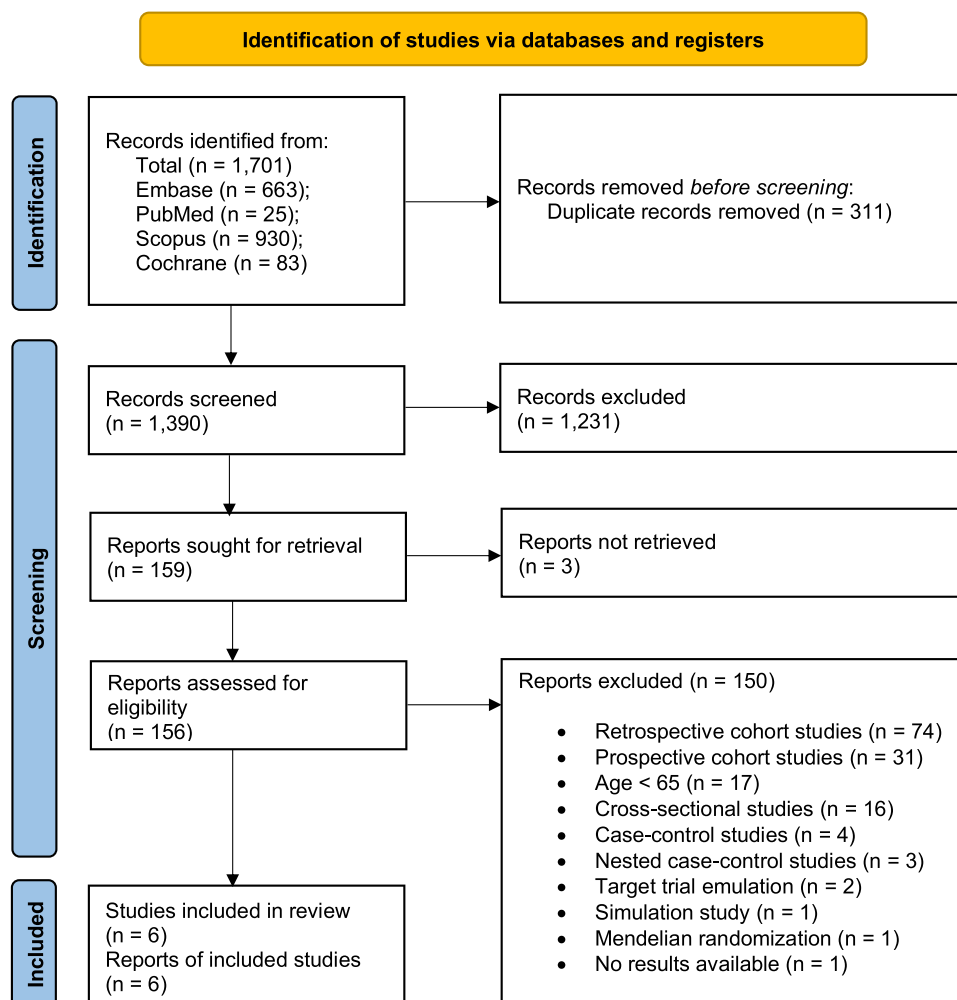


Figure 1 PRISMA flow diagram of study selection. The figure shows the process of identifying, screening, and assessing records for eligibility in the systematic review. **Abbreviation:** PRISMA, Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses.